

Maisarah WIZAN

Career profile

While I have a passion for and background in applied economics, I enjoy working in a multidisciplinary setting and learning about novel and mixed methodologies. In my work, I employ methods and perspectives across economics, sociology, as well as social and public policy. My doctoral research focuses on the measurement of income volatility in Belgium and the ability of social safety nets to protect against unexpected shocks to income.

Topics of interest: Applied econometrics | Economics of education | Labour economics | Social policy

Education

May 22–Present **PhD in Socio-economic Sciences**, *Herman Deleeck Centre for Social Policy, University of Antwerp*, Antwerp

Expected graduation/defence date: 14 September 2026

Visting Researcher at Luxembourg Institute of Socio-Economic Research (LISER), *April–May, 2025.*

Sep 20–Sep 21 **M.Sc. in Development Studies (Advanced Master's)**, *Institute of Development Policy (IOB), University of Antwerp*, Antwerp, *Great Distinction*

Interdisciplinary programme within the field of development studies

Feb 19–Jun 19 **Bachelor's Exchange Programme**, *Faculty of Business and Economics, University of Antwerp*, Antwerp

Some courses were also taken at the Faculty of Social Sciences. Enrolled for five courses (30 ECTS) in total, including two courses at Master's level:

- 'Public Finance (2109TEWECP)'
- 'Political Economy of Development (2200FSWEID)'

Aug 16–Jun 20 **B.Sc. (Honours) in Economics**, *National University of Singapore (NUS)*, Singapore, *Distinction (GPA: 4.37/5.00)*

Specialisation in Applied and Policy Economics

Minor in European Studies

Graduate and postgraduate courses taken during honours year (i.e., optional additional year to complete independent research):

- 'Policy Impact Evaluation Methods (EC5326R)' – applied econometrics
- 'Macroeconomic Analysis III (EC4302)' – inter-temporal optimisation models

Working Papers

Wizan, M. (2026). Lower Pay and Less Stable? Understanding the Migrant-Native Volatility Gap in Earnings. Unpublished manuscript (submission in preparation; available on request).

Wizan, M., Sologon, D.M. & Marchal, S. (2025). The Shift from Persistent Inequality to Earnings Instability in Belgium: A Longitudinal Decomposition by Gender and Education using Administrative Records, 2005–2021. IZA Discussion Paper No. 18132. Under review (Revise & Resubmit) at *Labour Economics*.

<https://www.iza.org/publications/dp/18132>

Publications

Wizan, M. & Marchal, S. (2026). Balancing Timeliness, Efficiency and Effectiveness: An Assessment of Targeted Social Policies in Challenging Times. *Social Policy & Administration*, 60, no. 1: 193–207.

<https://doi.org/10.1111/spol.13156>

Conferences and Presentations

- Jan 26 | Organising Committee, Speaker | AIPRIL/CHANGE Workshop "Changing work, changing incomes: assessing the vulnerability of non-standard workers and self employed", *University of Antwerp*
"Earnings volatility and dynamics: the migrant-native volatility gap in Belgium"
- Sep 25 | Speaker | Annual European Consortium for Sociological Research (ECSR) Conference: Demography and Social Inequality, *University of Cologne*
"Long-run inequality and instability in earnings in Belgium: the role of education and gender"
- Apr 25 | Speaker | HEC Liège Young Researchers Conference in Economics, *HEC Liège*
"Long-run inequality and instability in earnings over the lifecycle in Belgium, 2005-2021"
- May 23 | Speaker | 1st Welfare & Policy Conference, *Bordeaux School of Economics*
"Balancing speed and effectiveness: Smoothing income volatility through COVID-19 social policy responses in Belgium"
- Aug 22 | Participant | International Association for Research in Income and Wealth (IARIW) 37th General Conference, *Luxembourg*

Training and Workshops

- Oct, Nov 22 | EUROMOD Autumn Training & BELMOD Autumn Course
Courses and workshops in microsimulation
- Aug–Sep 22 | FLAMES Summer School
Longitudinal and Incomplete Data
Time Series Analysis
Essentials of R

Doctoral Thesis

- Title | *Socio-demographic Patterns of Instability: Essays on earnings and income volatility in Belgium*
- Supervisor | Prof. dr. Sarah Marchal
- Jury | Prof. dr. Ive Marx (UAntwerpen, chair), Prof. dr. Sunčica Vujić (UAntwerpen), Dr. Denisa Sologon (LISER), Prof. dr. Philippe Van Kerm (LISER, University of Luxembourg), Prof. dr. Stephen Jenkins (LSE)
- Description | The thesis investigates the evolution of earnings and income volatility in Belgium, with a focus on its socio-demographic determinants as well as how the design of social policies impact volatility. This empirical work makes use of large-scale administrative panel data (e.g., IPCAL tax data, demographic data from DEMOBEL, census data) using parametric (e.g., error components models) and non-parametric methods. Additionally, microsimulation and nowcasting techniques were used to create an intra-year dataset using survey and administrative data for the evaluation of social policy responses to the COVID-19 pandemic. The thesis is expected to be defended in September 2026. A copy of the thesis is available upon request.

Master's Thesis

Title	<i>Half-Earth, Conservation and New Media: An analysis of NGO narratives using the Narrative Policy Framework</i>
Supervisor	Prof.dr. Gert Van Hecken ↗
Grade	17/20
Description	The thesis explores how social media can be used in the construction of narratives about the 'Half-Earth' – the idea to conserve half of Earth's landmass by 2030. A mixed method approach, following the Narrative Policy Framework, is used on scraped Twitter data collected from various non-governmental organisations, who hold contesting notions about conservation. This thesis received a valorisation grant.

Bachelor's Thesis

Title	<i>A Student Fixed Effects Approach: Does computer use in classrooms improve test scores?</i>
Supervisor	Prof.dr. Nina Guyon ↗
Grade	A+ (~20/20)
Description	The thesis was written independently as part of the graduation requirements of the optional Honours' year. Using a student fixed effects model, alongside Oster's (2019) method in determining the extent of selection bias, the thesis investigates the causal effects of classroom computer use on test scores. (Full abstract ↗).

Awards and Achievements

- 2022 **Master's Thesis Valorisation Grant**
Amount: 1000€
Awarded to graduate students with dissertations of high quality for the valorisation of their thesis.
- 2020 **NUS Dean's Scholars List**, *Academic Year 2019-2020, Semester 2*
Amount: 100 SGD (66€)
Placed on the Dean's Scholars List for academic achievement, which recognises the top 1% of the faculty cohort of around 6000 students. [↗](#)
- 2019 **NUS Alumni Student Exchange Award**, *Academic Year 2018-2019*
Amount: 2500 SGD (1657€)
Awarded to students embarking on a semester abroad who have shown great involvement in co-curricular activities.

Languages

English	Native	Malay	Native
Bahasa Indonesia	Proficient (C1)	German	Intermediate (B1+) ↗
Spanish	Elementary (A2)	Dutch	Intermediate (B1) ↗

Computer skills

Software and programming	Stata (Proficient), R (Proficient), $\text{\LaTeX}$ (Proficient), NVivo (Intermediate), MATLAB (Basic), SPSS (Basic), SAS (Basic), Python (Basic), Excel VBA (Basic)
Miscellaneous	EUROMOD (Intermediate), Git (Basic)
Microsoft Office Suite	Excel, PowerPoint, Word (Proficient)

References

Name Sarah Marchal
Occupation Assistant Professor, UAntwerpen
Relationship PhD supervisor
Tel +32(0)032 65 19 20
Email sarah.marchal@uantwerpen.be

Name Gert Van Hecken
Occupation Assistant Professor, UAntwerpen
Relationship Master's thesis supervisor
Tel +32(0)032 65 56 85
Email gert.vanhecken@uantwerpen.be

Name Nina Guyon
Occupation Assistant Professor, Paris School of Economics
Relationship Bachelor's thesis supervisor
Email nina.guyon@ens.psl.eu